

Translation Quality Review — Scorer's Guide

Hi! You'll read a source sentence and one translation, and give each translation a score. This guide explains exactly what to look for.

What you're doing

You'll see:

- A **source sentence** (usually English)
- **One translation** of it in the target language (Chinese, Japanese, Korean, etc.)

For each translation, give two scores from **0 to 100**:

- **Accuracy** — does it say the same thing as the source?
- **Naturalness** — does it sound like a real native speaker wrote it?

Score each translation on its own. Don't compare them against each other when scoring — compare each to what a *perfect* translation would be.

How to score Accuracy

Ask yourself: *"If I only read the translation, would I get the exact same message as the source?"*

100 — Perfect. Every detail from the source is there. Names, numbers, dates, nuances — nothing lost, nothing added.

90 — Very good. Message is fully there, but one small nuance is softer (e.g. a hedging word dropped, an emphasis shifted).

80 — Good. You'd notice a small omission or slight shift if you compared side-by-side. Core meaning still intact.

70 — Okay. A noticeable part of the meaning changed or disappeared. Still recognizable as the same topic.

60 — Rough. Half the meaning is gone, or it's a loose paraphrase that *sort of* conveys the idea.

40 — Bad. Major errors. Only the topic is shared — details are wrong.

20 — Very bad. Feels like a different sentence entirely.

0 — Not a translation. Untranslated, gibberish, wrong language, or the source copied verbatim.

Feel free to pick in-between values (87, 73, etc.) — whatever feels right. Use 100 sparingly; save it for truly flawless translations.

Examples (English → Traditional Chinese)

Source	Translation	Score	Why
"The cat is on the mat."	貓在墊子上。	100	Exact match.
"The cat is on the mat."	貓在地板上。	60	"Mat" became "floor" — that's a real change.
"Please submit by Friday."	請於週五前提交。	100	Perfect.
"Please submit by Friday."	請提交。	70	Dropped "by Friday" — deadline lost.

How to score Naturalness

Ask yourself: *"If I showed this translation to a native speaker, would they even notice it was translated?"*

100 — Flawless. Reads exactly like a native speaker wrote **it in a 'local' way**. Proper grammar, right register, idiomatic, correct script conventions.

90 — Very natural. One tiny awkwardness or unusual word choice, but you'd say "yeah, a native speaker could write this."

80 — Natural but stiff. Understandable, clearly fluent, but feels a bit formal or wooden. Native might rephrase slightly.

70 — Readable with effort. Some translation-y feel. Grammar is right but phrasing isn't quite how natives talk.

60 — Clearly translated. Obvious "translationese." Grammar glitches. A native would rewrite this.

40 — Clunky and forced. Hard to read. Feels like someone is thinking in English and outputting another language.

20 — Broken. Grammar is wrong, or register is wildly off (e.g. casual slang where formal was needed).

0 — Unusable. Unintelligible, wrong script, or wrong language entirely.

Examples (English → Japanese)

Translation	Score	Why
明日は会議があります。	100	Natural Japanese. Polite, standard.
明日、私は会議を持っています。	60	Literal from "I have a meeting." Japanese says あります, not 持つ. Translation-y.
明日会議	40	No particles, no verb ending. Reads like a note, not a sentence.
Ashita wa kaigi ga arimasu.	0	Romaji only. Japanese needs kana/kanji.

Two important rules about "preservation"

Our translator has a specific job: when the content is **teaching a language**, certain words must stay in English (the language being taught). Here's how to handle this.

Rule 1: Curly braces `{{like this}}` are internal markers

Sometimes you might see a translation with words wrapped in double curly braces, like `{{freedom}}`. These are internal markers the pipeline uses to protect words from being translated.

The final user never sees these braces — our pipeline strips them before delivery.

What this means for you:

- If you see `{{freedom}}` in a translation: mentally remove the braces and check if the word "freedom" is there in English. Score based on that.
- The final delivered translation **should not** have `{{...}}` in it. If it does, it's a minor cosmetic issue (the content is still correct).
- What matters: is the word inside the braces preserved in the target text?

Examples:

Translation	Score impact
主詞「freedom」很重要。	Good. "freedom" preserved in English, braces correctly stripped.
主詞「自由」很重要。	Bad — accuracy -30. "freedom" was translated to 自由. Teaching token broken.
主詞「 <code>{{freedom}}</code> 」很重要。	Minor issue. Braces should've been stripped, but content is right. Small deduction.

Rule 2: English teaching words should stay in English

When the source is a lesson teaching English, English vocabulary words, quoted examples, and grammar terms must stay in English (Latin script). The student needs to see the English word to learn

it.

Examples:

Source	Translation	Score
Practice the word "horse".	練習「horse」這個詞。	Good — "horse" stays in English.
Practice the word "horse".	練習「馬」這個詞。	Bad — accuracy -30. "horse" was translated to 馬. Student can't see what to learn.
The verb "to run" means...	動詞「to run」的意思是...	Good.
The verb "to run" means...	動詞「跑」的意思是...	Bad — accuracy -30. Teaching target translated.

Things that commonly trip people up

Script matters a lot for naturalness

- **Japanese without kana/kanji (romaji only):** naturalness ≤ 40 , even if the meaning is perfect.
- **Thai without Thai script:** same.
- **Traditional Chinese with simplified characters** (e.g., 国 instead of 國): naturalness -10 to -20.

Length is not a quality signal

A shorter translation isn't automatically worse. A longer one isn't automatically better. Subtitles are often short by design. Just ask: does the meaning survive, and does it sound native?

Register (how formal it is) matters

- Formal source → casual target: **naturalness -15 to -25**.
- Casual source → overly formal target: **naturalness -15 to -25**.

Teacher-to-student "we" in Chinese should be 我們 (inclusive), not 我 (first-person-only) or 他們 (they). If that sounds wrong in the context, note it.

Beautiful but wrong

If a translation sounds absolutely gorgeous in the target language, but it changed what the source said — that's high **naturalness** (90+) but low **accuracy** (40-60). Score them **independently**.

Numbers and proper nouns

These must be exact. "Paris" shouldn't become "巴黎" unless the context clearly demands it (e.g., a tourism article for a local audience). "\$1,500" shouldn't become "1500 dollars" without the dollar sign, and definitely shouldn't become "\$1,000" or "\$15,000". Missing or wrong numbers = accuracy -20 at minimum.

Source-language idioms that leaked through

- "Take a seat" → "拿一個座位" (literal, awkward): naturalness 60.
- "Take a seat" → "請坐" (natural, idiomatic): naturalness 95+.

A good translation captures the *intent*, not the *words*.

How to submit your scores

For each row, we'll give you a simple form. Fill in integers 0-100 for each candidate you see:

```
row_id | version A: acc=__ nat=__ | version B: acc=__ nat=__ | notes
```

Notes are optional but hugely valuable. One-line observations like:

- "A preserved English word, B translated it — pedagogically wrong"
- "B more natural Chinese, A sounded translated"
- "Both had the same drift on 'by Friday'"

If two translations look identical, you can give them the same score (or leave the second blank; we'll understand).

The quick cheat sheet

Accuracy — does it say the same thing?

- **100**: perfect, nothing lost
- **90**: one tiny nuance dropped
- **80**: small omission or shift
- **70**: noticeable change, still on-topic
- **60**: half the meaning gone
- **< 50**: seriously wrong

Naturalness — does it sound native?

- **100**: indistinguishable from a native writer
- **90**: natural with one awkward spot
- **80**: comprehensible but stilted
- **70**: translation-y
- **60**: clearly machine-translated feel
- **< 50**: broken or very unnatural

Default stance: If in doubt, score slightly higher and note your hesitation. Stay consistent across rows. 100 is rare — save it for truly flawless work.

Thank you! Your scores directly shape what we ship to users.

#translator

#reviewer

#guide